The Life of Christ

Leader Guide — For Servants, Parents, and Group Leaders

> *"And beginning at Moses and all the Prophets, He expounded to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning Himself." — Luke 24:27*

Purpose of This Guide

This guide helps you lead The Life of Christ as a formation experience, not just a game. Each stage summary gives you the narrative arc, Gospel references, Coptic liturgical connections, and discussion prompts. The goal is for children to experience Christ's life as one story — a story they are part of.

Connecting to the Coptic Lectionary

The Coptic lectionary reads the four Gospels throughout the year, following the life of Christ in liturgical time. This game can be paired with the lectionary to reinforce what children hear in church:

- **Kiahk / Advent (month before Nativity):** Play Stages 1–2. The Church reads the Annunciation, Nativity, and Epiphany (Baptism) Gospels during this season.
- **Great Lent:** Play Stages 2–3. The Lenten readings focus on Christ's teaching, healing, and calling sinners to repentance.
- **Holy Week (Pascha):** Play Stages 4–5. Each day of Holy Week relives the Passion, Crucifixion, and Resurrection in extended prayers and readings.
- **The Fifty Days (Pentecost season):** Replay Stage 5, emphasising the Resurrection appearances and the Great Commission.
- **Any Sunday:** The full game works as a self-contained Sunday school session (30–40 minutes).

Before You Begin

- **Pray together.** Begin with a short prayer: "Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, open our hearts to walk with You today — from the manger to the Cross, and from the tomb to heaven. Amen."
- **Set the context.** Tell the group: "Today we are going to walk through Jesus' whole life together. Everything He did was for us. Let's see how the story unfolds."
- **Assign the Reader role** to a confident reader. Rotate each turn so everyone gets a chance.

Stage 1: Birth and Childhood

The Gospel Story

The Archangel Gabriel announces to the Virgin Mary that she will bear the Son of God (Luke 1:26–38). Jesus is born in Bethlehem (Luke 2:1–7), visited by shepherds (Luke 2:8–20) and Magi (Matthew 2:1–12). The Holy Family flees to Egypt to escape Herod (Matthew 2:13–18). Jesus is presented in the Temple (Luke 2:22–40) and at age twelve astonishes the teachers there (Luke 2:41–52).

Coptic Liturgical Connections

- The **Feast of the Nativity** (7 January / 29 Kiahk) is one of the seven major feasts. The month of Kiahk is filled with praises to the Theotokos.
- The **Feast of the Holy Family in Egypt** (1 June / 24 Bashans) celebrates Christ's blessing of the land of Egypt. The Coptic Church traces sacred sites the Holy Family visited.
- The **Feast of the Presentation** (8 February / 2 Amshir) remembers Simeon's prophecy: "A light for revelation to the Gentiles."

Teaching Card Prompt

"The Boy Jesus in the Temple" — Ask: "Jesus said He had to be in His Father's house. Where is God's house today? How can we be close to God the way Jesus was?" Help children see that the Church, their homes, and their own hearts are places where God dwells.

Stage 2: Baptism and Temptation

The Gospel Story

John the Baptist prepares the way (Mark 1:1–8). Jesus is baptised in the Jordan and the Holy Trinity is revealed (Matthew 3:13–17). He is led into the wilderness for forty days, where He overcomes Satan's three temptations with Scripture (Matthew 4:1–11). He calls His first disciples (John 1:35–51) and performs His first miracle at the wedding in Cana (John 2:1–11).

Coptic Liturgical Connections

- The **Feast of Epiphany** (19 January / 11 Toba) celebrates Christ's Baptism. The Coptic Church blesses water on this day, recalling the sanctification of the Jordan.
- The **Great Lent** begins with a focus on fasting and resisting temptation, echoing Christ's forty days in the wilderness.
- The Baptism reveals the **Holy Trinity** — the Father speaks, the Son is baptised, the Spirit descends. This is central to Coptic theology and is recalled in every Liturgy.

Teaching Card Prompt

“John the Baptist Prepares” — Ask: “John told people to get ready for Jesus. How do we prepare to meet Jesus? What do we do before taking Communion?” Connect to the practice of fasting, confession, and prayer before receiving the Eucharist.

Stage 3: Ministry and Teaching

The Gospel Story

Jesus' public ministry spans roughly three years. He feeds the five thousand (John 6:1–14), walks on water (Matthew 14:22–33), is transfigured on the mountain (Matthew 17:1–8), heals the blind (John 9), raises Lazarus (John 11), teaches in parables (Luke 10; 15), calms storms (Mark 4:35–41), heals the paralytic (Mark 2:1–12), meets the Samaritan woman (John 4), sends out the seventy (Luke 10:1–20), faces opposition (Matthew 12), receives Peter's confession (Matthew 16:13–20), dines with Zacchaeus (Luke 19:1–10), blesses children (Mark 10:13–16), and challenges the rich young ruler (Mark 10:17–27).

Coptic Liturgical Connections

- The **Sunday Gospel readings** throughout the year draw heavily from Christ's ministry. Each Sunday's Gospel reading is an encounter with Christ's teaching and miracles.
- The **Feast of the Transfiguration** (19 August / 13 Mesra) reveals Christ's divine glory. The Coptic hymn “Eporo” celebrates this mystery.
- **Lazarus Saturday** (the day before Palm Sunday) commemorates the raising of Lazarus, a foretaste of Christ's own resurrection.

Teaching Card Prompts

- **“The Good Samaritan”** — Ask: “Who is my neighbour? Can you think of someone at school or church who needs help?”
- **“The Prodigal Son”** — Ask: “The father ran to his son. What does that tell us about how God feels when we come back to Him?”
- **“The Woman at the Well”** — Ask: “Jesus offered living water. What is the living water? How do we receive it?”
- **“Peter's Confession”** — Ask: “Who do you say Jesus is? How would you explain Jesus to a friend?”
- **“The Rich Young Ruler”** — Ask: “What holds us back from following Jesus completely? What are we afraid to give up?”

Stage 4: Passion and Cross

The Gospel Story

Jesus enters Jerusalem on Palm Sunday (Matthew 21:1–11). He shares the Last Supper with His disciples, instituting the Eucharist (Luke 22:14–20) and washing their feet (John 13:1–17). He prays in agony at Gethsemane (Luke 22:39–46), is betrayed by Judas (Matthew 26:47–56), denied by Peter (Luke 22:54–62), tried before Pilate (John 18:28–19:16), crucified (John 19:17–30), and buried in a new tomb (John 19:38–42).

Coptic Liturgical Connections

- **Holy Week (Pascha)** is the most solemn and longest liturgical observance in the Coptic Church. Services run from Palm Sunday through Bright Saturday, with readings covering every detail of the Passion.
- The **Covenant Thursday** Liturgy commemorates the Last Supper. The priest washes the congregation's feet, following Christ's example.
- The **Good Friday** prayers last from morning until evening, walking through the Crucifixion hour by hour. The Church is draped in black.
- The **Apocalypse (Revelation)** is read only during Holy Week, reminding believers that the Cross leads to ultimate victory.

Teaching Card Prompts

- **"The Last Supper"** — Ask: "Why is the Eucharist so important? What happens when we take Communion?" Help children connect the game to their experience of receiving the Body and Blood in the Liturgy.
- **"Washing the Disciples' Feet"** — Ask: "Jesus was the Lord of everything, but He knelt down to serve. How can we serve others this week?"

Stage 5: Resurrection and Ascension

The Gospel Story

On the third day, the women find the tomb empty (Matthew 28:1–8). Jesus appears to Mary Magdalene (John 20:11–18), to the two disciples on the road to Emmaus (Luke 24:13–35), and to Thomas (John 20:24–29). He gives the Great Commission (Matthew 28:18–20) and ascends to heaven (Acts 1:6–11).

Coptic Liturgical Connections

- The **Resurrection Liturgy** begins at midnight on Bright Saturday. The Church is transformed from mourning to joy. "Ekhrestos anesti! Alethos anesti!" (Christ is risen! Truly He is risen!)
- The **Fifty Days** between Resurrection and Pentecost are a season of joy. No fasting, no kneeling. The Church celebrates the risen Christ.
- The **Feast of the Ascension** (forty days after Resurrection) is a major feast. Christ's Ascension opens heaven for humanity.
- The Gospel of **Thomas's confession** ("My Lord and my God!") holds special significance for the Coptic Church, as Thomas is traditionally associated with the evangelisation of Egypt's neighbour, India.

Teaching Card Prompts

- **"The Road to Emmaus"** — Ask: "The disciples recognised Jesus in the breaking of bread. Where do we meet Jesus today?" Connect to the Eucharist and to reading Scripture together.
- **"Doubting Thomas"** — Ask: "Thomas needed to see to believe. How do we believe without seeing? What helps your faith grow?"

Connecting to the Children's Lives

After the game, take a few minutes to bridge from the story to the children's experience:

- "We saw that Jesus needed faith, courage, love, and prayer on His journey. **Which resource do you need most right now?**"
- "The disciples walked with Jesus together. **Who walks with you** — at home, at church, at school?"
- "The Passion stage was hard and we almost ran out of resources. **Have you ever felt like you were running out of faith or courage?** What helped you?"
- "The Resurrection changed everything. **What gives you hope** when things are difficult?"

Closing Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, You walked this earth for us. You were born for us, baptised for us, tempted for us, and You suffered and died for us. You rose from the dead and ascended into heaven, opening the way for us to follow. Help us to walk with You every day — with faith, courage, love, and prayer. Through the intercessions of the Theotokos Saint Mary and all the saints, keep us on the path that leads to You. Amen.*

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